AFTER ACTION REVIEW
OF UNDP CORPORATE RESPONSE
TO THE CRISIS IN SYRIA

FINAL REPORT

May 2026

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LIST OF ACRONYMS

AAR	After Action Review
BCP	Business Continuity Plan
BERA	Bureau for External Relations and Advocacy
BMS	Bureau for Management Support
BPPS	Bureau for Policy and Programme Support
CB	Crisis Board
CMST	Crisis Management Support Team
CO	Country Office
FGD	Focus Group Discussion
FW	Funding Window
HQ	Headquarters
IDP	Internally Displaced Persons
IR	Inception Report
IRG	Internationally Recognized Government
KII	Key Informant Interview
RBAS	Regional Bureau for Arab States
RM	Resource Mobilization
RR	Resident Representative
SCO	Syria Country Office
SEIA	Socio-Economic Impact Assessment
SM	Special Measures
SOPs	Corporate Standard Operating Procedures for Immediate Crisis Response
SSF	Syria Stabilization Facility
STAF	Syria Technical Assistance Facility
ToRs	Terms of Reference
UN	United Nations
UNDP	United Nations Development Programme
USD	United States Dollars
WSC	Women’s Safe Centres
WPS	Women Peace and Security

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

UNDP CORPORATE RESPONSE TO THE CRISIS

STRATEGIC DECISIONS

The strategic decisions taken at global, regional and country levels were instrumental in enabling UNDP to reposition itself rapidly in Syria's evolving transition context. The L3 Crisis declaration and its extension unlocked TRAC3 funding, Special Measures and sustained corporate support, while high-level engagement from HQ and RBAS helped the CO build access, credibility and trust with the new authorities. Core resources were used catalytically, particularly through the Syria Technical Assistance Facility, which embedded technical expertise across key government institutions and contributed to positioning UNDP as a trusted partner, although sustaining this support will require continued resource mobilization and risk-informed flexibility.

At country level, the CO's deliberate trust-building approach, dynamic scenario-based offer and prioritization of critical initiatives allowed UNDP to move from a constrained humanitarian role toward a broader stabilization and development agenda, despite continued challenges linked to sanctions, donor hesitancy, banking constraints and the time required to build effective relationships with the new Government.

WHOLE OF UNDP APPROACH AND SOPS

Overall, UNDP largely adhered to the Standard Operating Procedures for Crisis Response by promptly convening the Crisis Board, activating immediate readiness measures including the Business Continuity Plan and Crisis Management Support Team, and approving operational flexibility through Special Measures. While the release of TRAC3 resources was delayed by legal and operational complexities linked to sanctions, limited engagement by the caretaker authorities, and their initial mistrust of the UN, the organization adopted a clear "whole of UNDP" approach. This included high-level corporate and regional engagement, combined TRAC2 and TRAC3 financial support, and extensive technical assistance from RBAS, the Regional Hub, the Crisis Bureau, BERA and BMS. Through multiple specialized and multidisciplinary missions, the organization supported the Country Office in identifying programmatic opportunities and shaping a comprehensive offer across governance, rule of law, peacebuilding, economic recovery, energy, environment, sustainable finance, inclusive growth and health, while BERA strengthened donor mapping and advocacy and BMS enabled additional exceptional Special Measures.

HIGH-LEVEL CORPORATE SUPPORT

UNDP's high-level engagement provided essential political backing and strategic positioning for the Country Office during the early phase of Syria's transition. Key missions to Damascus, particularly the December 2024 visit by the Regional Director and the Crisis Bureau Deputy Director, helped reset relations with caretaker authorities that were initially distrustful of UN agencies and facilitated early access to senior counterparts and opened doors that reportedly remained closed to much of the wider UN system. Corporate advocacy further strengthened UNDP's positioning, notably through the Administrator's participation in the Brussels Conference, which elevated recovery and development issues in an otherwise humanitarian-focused forum. Internally, the February 2025 multidisciplinary scoping mission helped shape a programmatic offer that the CO used to engage ministries over the following months, and overall, the high-level investment of senior UNDP officials was considered beneficial and effective.

PROGRAMMATIC ASPECTS OF THE RESPONSE

PERTINENCE AND TIMELINESS OF THE PROGRAMMATIC RESPONSE

UNDP's programmatic response in Syria was highly pertinent, addressing acute structural, economic and institutional needs in parallel with the humanitarian response of other actors. Its early focus on energy, including support to the National Electricity Master Plan and an assurance role in gas supply initiatives, was a relevant entry point given energy's centrality to health, water, agriculture, humanitarian assistance and economic recovery, and contributed to a visible peace dividend through increased power supply in Damascus. The response also addressed the severe weakening of public institutions after 14 years of conflict through the STAF, which provided demand-driven technical expertise embedded in Ministries and helped restore core Government functions.

In terms of timeliness, the response was marked by an initial six-month halt caused by mistrust from the caretaker authorities and their review of UN operations, and legal concerns on the UN side, linked to sanctions; however, UNDP used this period to build trust, reposition itself and prepare for scale-up. Once engagement resumed in mid-2025, the CO rapidly expanded delivery from approximately USD 13.6 million to over USD 80 million by year-end, while resource mobilization rose from around USD 7 million to about USD 150 million. Although the initial period constituted a delay, informants agreed that it was largely unavoidable and ultimately enabled UNDP to strategize, restructure and build the relationships necessary to deliver a significantly expanded response once conditions allowed.

SYRIA TECHNICAL ASSISTANCE FACILITY

The Syria Technical Assistance Facility (STAF), established in 2025, emerged as a rapid and highly relevant response to the institutional needs of the transition, providing demand-driven technical expertise, policy guidance, equipment and rehabilitation support to the new government. It quickly became an essential engagement platform, helping UNDP build close dialogue with national authorities and position itself as a partner of choice. STAF contributed to policy and strategy development, master planning, social protection and poverty analysis, donor proposal development, investor dialogue and emergency responses, while also enabling Ministries to resume basic functions through essential assets and office support. A key achievement was the recruitment and embedding of 48 Syrian diaspora and local experts across six Ministries and Government institutions, addressing acute capacity gaps through a "reverse brain drain" approach that was well suited to the political sensitivity of the context and contributed to sustainable capacity transfer.

Currently, the Facility faces some challenges, particularly around long-term financial sustainability, donor hesitancy to fund public sector capacity building, and expectation management among unsupported Ministries. Its early request-driven model proved reactive, prompting UNDP to move toward a more proactive, consolidated and Government-owned technical assistance plan. A notable weakness is the deterioration of gender integration across successive STAF designs, with gender shifting from a standalone output with dedicated resources to a mainstreamed reference, thereby reducing its programmatic weight and practical implications.

STABILIZATION PLUS

UNDP's programmatic offer in Syria evolved from an initial scenario-based framework into the Stabilization Plus approach and, by early 2026, into the design of the Syria Stabilization Facility, structured around community security, infrastructure and service delivery, and income support to support sustainable returns and stabilization. Across its iterations, the framework remained aligned with UNDP's strategic priorities and the needs identified by the Syrian authorities, focusing on governance and public sector reform, economic recovery and livelihoods, and energy and environment, with forced displacement and gender equality as cross-cutting themes. Its flexibility was a key strength, allowing UNDP to adapt to a fluid and uneven context, begin with less controversial entry points, and present a coherent narrative to Government and donors at a time when programmatic engagement was still limited. This contributed to UNDP's positioning as a strategic development partner, supported the near doubling of delivery to around USD 80 million, and helped mobilize close to USD 150 million. The alignment between the framework and STAF was also coherent, as STAF operationalized the demand-driven flexibility required by the context. However, confirmation of targeted stabilization support to conflict-affected locations such as Sweida through the GFFO–UNDP Stabilization Response Mechanism (SRM) was only secured by February 2026, reflecting the earlier prioritization of Gaza within the SRM.

GENDER EQUALITY

The integration of gender equality in UNDP's Syria crisis response presents a mixed picture, with notable efforts but also significant weaknesses in analysis, design and institutional positioning. The SEIA, as a key analytical foundation, contained limited sex-disaggregated data and insufficient analysis of the differentiated impacts of the conflict on women and men, reflecting broader constraints in national data systems and data collection methodologies. While the CO Gender Team had previously produced several gender analyses and a first post-transition participatory gender analysis was being finalized at the time of the AAR, gender was not consistently embedded across response design. The February 2025 scoping mission included some relevant recommendations, and the initial STAF design contained a strong standalone gender output with dedicated resources above the corporate GEN3 threshold; however, subsequent project revisions weakened this architecture by shifting gender to a cross-cutting principle with limited operational detail. Similarly, STAF advisor ToRs did not systematically include gender requirements, and the SSF concept note makes only limited reference to gender-specific interventions, suggesting a pattern of gender being acknowledged rather than designed into programming from the outset. This is not consistent with UNDP's corporate commitment to gender equality. At the same time, the CO shows important positive foundations, including senior-level gender champions, an active gender portfolio, and the inclusion of gender equality as the fourth pillar of the forthcoming CPD. However, the current gender team capacity and formal positioning appear insufficient for the scale of responsibilities, and should be strengthened to match the stated strategic priority.

OPERATIONAL ASPECTS OF THE RESPONSE

SPECIAL MEASURES

Following Syria's L3 designation, the Country Office was able to access both pre-approved and exceptional Special Measures, formally activated in January 2025 and later extended for an additional year, which created a critical enabling environment for rapid operational scale-up. The CO used 86 pre-approved measures with a combined delivery value of approximately USD 8.1 million, particularly in HR, procurement, finance and programming, with HR measures supporting accelerated recruitment and procurement flexibilities enabling rehabilitation, renewable energy and solid waste activities. Programmatic measures were less frequent but highly valued, especially the removal of the cumulative cap on low-value grants and the waiver of micro-assessments, which were important in a context where trusted partners were limited. In addition, eight exceptional measures were approved for Syria, including increased procurement delegation and the ability to pay local vendors in USD, both of which proved essential given inflation, liquidity constraints and the collapse of the banking system. The CO strongly valued these flexibilities, which, together with Crisis Bureau-funded UNVs, supported delivery of USD 80 million in 2025. However, cash management remained the most significant operational constraint, as existing measures were not sufficient for the extreme breakdown of Syria's financial system, and required extraordinary measures to ensure the continuity of operations. The Syria experience also highlights the value of measuring time saved through Special Measures, as a proxy for efficiency and timeliness, and as possible evidence for simplifying selected processes beyond crisis settings.

SURGE

SURGE support to the Syria CO was limited in terms of personnel deployments, as the CO prioritized flexible funding over deployed staff due to uncertainty and evolving Government demands. The only standard SURGE deployment took place between October and November 2025 to provide durable solutions expertise in a context of approximately 12 million displaced persons.

Additional Crisis Bureau support funded through SURGE included mine action advisory missions in June and September 2025, linked to Project Revive and engagement with the National Mine Action Centre. These missions were strategically relevant and generated concrete recommendations, including the hiring of a dedicated mine action advisor; however, the lack of follow-through on this position may have limited UNDP's ability to consolidate its positioning in this area. Nevertheless, new opportunities emerged, particularly with Syria being considered in early 2026 as a pilot for a joint UN mine action roadmap and with a planned UNDP–UNMAS assessment mission to develop a comprehensive national mine action strategy.

CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

CONCLUSIONS

Syria's 2024 political transition presented UNDP with an exceptionally complex operating environment, marked by collapsed institutions, economic devastation, sanctions-related constraints, and initial distrust from the new authorities. In this context, the CO's ability to pivot from a restricted humanitarian role to a broader stabilization and development response, deliver over USD 80 million, and mobilize approximately USD 150 million represents a significant achievement, made possible by strong engagement across the organization. The initial six-month trust-building period delayed implementation but also allowed the CO to prepare strategically for rapid scale-up once engagement became possible. At HQ level, the response was swift and appropriate, with the timely L3 declaration, rapid Crisis Board mobilization, sustained senior leadership support, and the Administrator's participation at the Brussels Conference helping elevate development priorities. TRAC resources again proved catalytic, enabling UNDP to position itself with authorities, donors and partners, and should therefore be protected despite the current constrained global financial environment. At regional level, RBAS and the Regional Hub provided strong programmatic support through scoping and technical missions, while continuity and deep contextual knowledge — including from regional and CO leadership — were critical enabling factors for strategic positioning and effective engagement.

At CO level, the response was particularly strong in strategic design and execution: UNDP demonstrated resilience and adaptability, built trust with initially cautious authorities, developed a credible programmatic offer, launched STAF as a flagship technical assistance platform, and scaled delivery sharply in the second half of 2025. The demand-driven and increasingly Government-owned approach to technical assistance was appropriate to the context, and the CO's preference for flexible funding over deployed personnel was a legitimate operating choice aligned with sustainability considerations. A more structural concern cuts across all levels: despite positive commitments by the CO, senior management and Gender Team, gender equality was not consistently integrated as a corporate responsibility. It was largely absent from the SEIA, progressively weakened in programmatic documents, insufficiently reflected in UNV ToRs, and remained overly dependent on an under-resourced CO unit. This reflects a systemic cultural and accountability gap, rather than only a country-level issue, and requires correction to ensure that gender equality is treated as a core mandate rather than an optional add-on.

RECOMMENDATIONS

For Syria CO

- Strengthen gender equality as a programmatic pillar
- Embed gender equality requirements systematically in all ToRs, programmatic and monitoring documents

For RBAS

- Establish a mandatory gender equality review for all regional products
- Explore the feasibility of a regional stabilization facility

For the Crisis Bureau

- Address gender equality as a corporate culture issue in crisis response
- Assess eligibility and implications of high-impact Special Measures for extension to non-crisis contexts.
- Evaluate the implications and practical aspects of providing TRAC3 "loans" to COs beyond the existing SOP standards.

For BMS

- Promote efficiency through the expansion of high-impact Special Measures to non-crisis contexts

INTRODUCTION

In December 2024, Syria underwent a historic political transition following the collapse of the Assad regime. Caretaker authorities, led by opposition factions, assumed control, initiating a critical transitional period and opening for early recovery.

UNDP declared a Level 3 crisis at the first Crisis Board Meeting on 9 December 2024, which was extended until the end of 2025 and recently again until May 2026. Upon declaration, the Crisis Bureau (CB) provided the Syria Country Office (SCO) with USD 1.35M in TRAC3 funding to establish the Syria Technical Assistance Facility (STAF), delivering urgent strategic, policy, and technical support to the transitional authorities to strengthen governance, restore services, and lay the groundwork for recovery. In addition, both the Crisis Bureau and the Regional Bureau for Arab States (RBAS) and the Regional Hub, as well as the Bureau for Management Support (BMS) and the Bureau for External Relations and Advocacy (BERA) provided comprehensive support to the CO to respond to the crisis. The collective organizational effort and its results are the subject of the present light After Action Review (AAR).

AAR GOALS, SCOPE AND METHODOLOGY

The goal of the AAR is to conduct a structured reflection on the crisis response to identify strengths and weaknesses, lessons learned and good practices, to sustain and multiply what was done well, and to identify and correct areas for improvement. The present AAR, designed as a light exercise, covers the period of the activation of the corporate response to the Syria crisis from its beginning in December 2024 up to the Country Management Support Team (CMST) meeting held in February 2026. It analyzes the key areas covered in the Terms of Reference (ToRs), which include:

Overall clarity and timeliness of decision making for the response	Timeliness and effectiveness of programmatic response and corporate funds	Effectiveness of the operational response

Some elements have been identified during inception as being of particular interest, including the high-level strategic support for CO positioning, the programmatic response including the Syria Technical Assistance Facility and the Stabilization Plus programme, and the application of Special Measures (SM).

Strategic support and high-level engagement for CO positioning in the new context	Syria Technical Assistance Facility (STAF)	Stabilization Plus programme	Special Measures (SM)

The methodology is described in more detail in Annex 2.

Limitations: The limited resources allocated to the AAR significantly constrained the scope and depth of the data collection. As a result, consultations had to be severely prioritized, which restricted engagement with several key informants whose insights would have been valuable to understand specific aspects of the response. The absence of available written documentation related to these same aspects limited the possibility to mitigate the gap through secondary sources.

ANALYSIS OF THE SYRIA CRISIS RESPONSE

UNDP CORPORATE RESPONSE TO THE CRISIS

STRATEGIC DECISIONS

Key strategic decisions were taken rapidly and effectively both at corporate and at country level. The table below summarizes the key decisions and their impact.

Strategic decisions	Description and effects
GLOBAL AND REGIONAL LEVEL	
Declaration and extension of the Level 3 (L3) Crisis status	In December 2024, HQ declared an L3 crisis following the collapse of the previous regime and the ensuing political transition. The CB repeatedly reviewed and decided to extend the L3 classification and associated special measures throughout 2025 and into 2026, to sustain the crisis response and to allow for operational flexibility. The L3 declaration created an enabling environment that unlocked catalytic TRAC3 funding and special measures, and extensive corporate support from HQ and regional levels of the organization.
High-level engagement for CO positioning	UNDP deployed its support to the CO from the highest level, including the prompt mission from the RBAS Regional Director and Crisis Bureau Deputy Director , the participation of the UNDP Administrator in the March 2025 Brussels Conference, and subsequent missions from senior regional management to meet with caretaker authorities, leveraging organizational weight and connections. UNDP corporate support to the CO worked well by facilitating access that was denied to other UN organizations and contributing to building the trust that was necessary to unlock collaboration with the authorities; additionally, the participation of the UNDP Administrator at the Brussels Conference gave development issues an unprecedented weight in the discussions, compared to the past.
Strategic allocation of core funding	The Crisis Board allocated USD 1.35M of TRAC3 resources, which provided essential funds for technical assistance, policy support and institutional strengthening. These were coupled with TRAC 2 funds from RBAS of approximately USD 3M allocated to technical assistance, critical recovery needs and gender equality initiatives. These resources proved catalytic as they were used jointly to fund, among other things, the demand-driven Technical Assistance Facility, that responded to Government requests for support and contributed to position UNDP as a trusted partner capable of addressing urgent institutional gaps. Thanks to STAF, approximately 48 advisors have been embedded across 6 Ministries/Government Institutions, developing a solid relationship between UNDP and the caretaker authorities, which later became the internationally recognized Government (IRG) of Syria, and making of UNDP a partner of choice for the new Government. The scenario-based offer designed by UNDP in the first weeks and months (also supported by TRAC3 funds) allowed it to successfully increase its resource mobilization from approximately USD 7M in June 2025 to USD 150M only six months later. Given the exceptional situation of Syria, some informants consider that the time-bound nature of TRAC3 resources may be too constrained for the requirements of a multi-year political transition. Continuing to raise external funding to sustain the STAF remains a challenge, as many partners continue to be hesitant to invest in Government capacity building. As of early 2026, UNDP intends to continue the provision of technical assistance through an expanded facility for a period of three years, with a funding requirement of approximately USD 20M.
Approval of Special Measures (SM)	BMS and HQ approved a suite of exceptional special measures, in addition to the pre-approved ones applicable to countries in crisis, to expedite implementation. Among these measures there are fast-track recruitments, increased procurement delegations, financial waivers (such as paying local vendors in USD, which contributed to attracting suppliers). The fast-track recruitment and devolution of hiring also allowed the office to accelerate standard timeframes for recruitment. The specific situation of Syria would

	have benefitted, according to key informants, from a higher organizational risk appetite in terms of cash management, as the extreme challenges of the banking system required complex solutions to ensure payments. Special Measures are discussed more in detail here.
COUNTRY LEVEL	
Trust-building effort	For the first six months after the change in regime, the CO with support from HQ and Regional levels strategically engaged with the new authorities to build trust and open opportunities for future programmatic initiatives. This phase was crucial due to the diffident posture of the authorities, suspicious of UN agencies who had worked with the previous regime. UNDP used multiple high-level missions to reset the relationship and demonstrate UNDP's commitment to development. Direct engagement by the departing Resident Representative also helped open doors. The process took around six months, until the summer of 2025; multiple informants agreed that it would have not been possible to speed it up, as trust is built with time (an inelastic variable). Additionally, some consider that pushing more would have been counter-productive, as demonstrated in the case of the UN-backed Transitional Action Plan (TAP), which backfired when the new authorities perceived it as an attempt by the UN to impose a course of action onto them.
Dynamic scenario-based offer	The CO, with support from the Crisis Bureau and RBAS, developed an "Immediate and Mid-Term Scenario-Based Offer" (later evolving into Stabilization Plus programmatic offer) to maintain flexibility across different political outcomes and adapt rapidly to the evolving dynamics in country. This worked well by providing a flexible, demand-driven framework that allowed UNDP to pivot from limited humanitarian support – as it had been limited to in the previous 14 years - to a broader stabilization and development role, leading to a doubling of programmatic delivery up to USD 80M in 2025. The support to transition was articulated in priorities for the first 100 days and mid-term priorities, articulated in advisory support to IRG, socio-economic recovery, provision of basic social services, strengthening of local governance, and rehabilitation of critical infrastructure. In early 2026, the stabilization approach and offer have further evolved into the conceptualization of a Syria Stabilization Facility (SSF).
Establishment of the Syria Technical Assistance Facility (STAF)	UNDP immediately established this demand-driven Facility to provide policy support, technical expertise, and equipment to newly formed Government Ministries; this initiative strongly contributed to the trust developed by the Government over time. As mentioned earlier, it allowed UNDP to respond immediately to Government requests and successfully embedded 48 advisors across 6 Ministries/Government Institutions, addressing the "brain drain" by recruiting Syrian diaspora experts to strengthen institutional capacity. The STAF is discussed more in detail here.
Prioritization of Critical Initiatives	The CO chose to focus initially on critical infrastructure, such as the Electricity Master Plan and the Deir Ali Thermal Power Station as foundational entry points, recognizing energy as an enabler for all other recovery sectors and for humanitarian action as well. Another critical initiative was the facilitation of payment of the education sector salaries, thanks to USD 90M from Saudi and Qatari funding, which both served as an important injection of liquidity in the local economy and a measure to create some fiscal space for the Government. However, these initiatives faced delays: for instance, the salary project was stalled for months because Gulf donors feared being impacted by American sanctions. Furthermore, high-cost infrastructure projects struggled to gain traction because the large investment required were seen as too sensitive or risky for many donors during the transition period.

WHOLE OF UNDP APPROACH AND SOPS

Overall, the organization followed the **Standard Operating Procedures for Crisis Response** (SOPs) by convening the Crisis Board meeting, undertaking immediate crisis readiness actions, including the activation of the Business Continuity Plan (BCP), activating the Crisis Management Support Team

(CMST), and approving flexibility measures. TRAC3 resources were released several weeks after the first Crisis Board meeting, due to the fact that the new caretaker authorities were under international sanctions, requiring a clarification of legal implications and the permissible extent of UN engagement with them; moreover, these same authorities initially halted engagement with the United Nations and programmatic activities due to a combination of assessing ongoing operations, mistrust of the UN, and their own limited immediate capacity.

Besides the high-level support provided by the most senior officers at corporate and regional level, and the joint financial support with TRAC2 and TRAC3 resources described above, the organization clearly took a **'whole of UNDP' approach** in providing full scale technical support: the Regional Bureau and Hub deployed multiple specialized missions to identify programmatic opportunities and support the CO in designing a comprehensive offer. Technical support was also provided from different Bureaus at HQ including Crisis Bureau, BERA and BMS. Seven regional missions, including multiple multidisciplinary ones, took place between December 2024 and February 2026; they provided the CO with comprehensive technical support and a wide menu of options for governance, rule of law, peacebuilding, economic recovery, energy and environment, sustainable finance, inclusive growth, health and others programmatic aspects. The Crisis Bureau provided support on mine action through a technical advisor and on durable solutions through a SURGE deployment.
Simultaneously, BERA worked with the Country Office to map donor positions and coordinate high-level advocacy, such as the Administrator's participation in the Brussels Conference, while BMS approved exceptional Special Measures, in addition to the existing ones already available to countries in crisis.

HIGH-LEVEL CORPORATE SUPPORT

UNDP at HQ and regional levels provided critical high-level political backing to the CO through direct missions to Damascus, most notably the December 2024 visit from the Regional Director and the Crisis Bureau Deputy Director. These engagements were strategically designed to reset the relationship with the caretaker authorities, who initially distrusted UN agencies due to their previous work with the former regime.

Corporate support also manifested through strategic advocacy and positioning on the global stage, particularly through the UNDP Administrator's participation in the Brussels Conference. By representing the development mandate of the UN in a forum traditionally dominated by humanitarian concerns, HQ helped elevate transition and recovery issues to a priority level for international donors.

Internally, a multidisciplinary scoping mission led by the Regional Hub Director in February 2025 contributed technical expertise to articulate the programmatic offer, which the CO used as a primary tool to engage various Ministries in dialogue for weeks and months to come.

Overall, the high-level investment of senior UNDP officials has been beneficial and brought positive results.

PROGRAMMATIC ASPECTS OF THE RESPONSE

The programmatic response was structured as a strategic pivot from the restricted humanitarian focus that had been possible under the previous regime, towards a broader model of stabilization, early recovery, and development. This shift was articulated in the "Immediate and Mid-Term Scenario-Based Offer," later evolving into the "Stabilization Plus" framework, designed to be flexible across three scenarios: the formation of an internationally recognized Government, the persistence of a *de facto* authority, or a relapse into conflict. The response was sequenced in:

- Immediate Actions (0–6 months): Prioritized "quick-win" support, needs assessments, and the rehabilitation of critical sectors, including for example agriculture, education, health, rubble removal, water, and energy.
- Short-to-Medium Term Action (6–18 months): Included advisory support to IRG, to strengthening the social contract; socio-economic recovery and social protection, strengthening local governance and providing basic social services, and rehabilitate critical infrastructure.

PERTINENCE AND TIMELINESS OF THE PROGRAMMATIC RESPONSE

UNDP's programmatic response in Syria was **highly pertinent** to the crisis context, as it addressed directly the country's most acute structural, economic, and institutional needs – in parallel with the humanitarian response provided by other actors focused on assessed humanitarian needs.

For example, the initial focus on energy was justified by its being critical for many other sectors, including health, water, agriculture, humanitarian aid, and economic recovery. UNDP's prioritization of the National Electricity Master Plan and its "assurance" role in gas supply initiatives were a pertinent entry point: over time these interventions resulted in an increase of power supply in Damascus from 2 to 12 hours per day, providing a visible "peace dividend", and restoring critical lifelines.

On the short and medium term, the response was equally pertinent. Syrian public institutions were severely weakened by 14 years of conflict and a massive loss of technical expertise; UNDP's response through the STAF directly addressed this aspect, by providing demand-driven institutional strengthening through specialized technical advisors embedded in Ministries. This injected essential capacity into core Government functions, enabling the newly formed Government to resume service delivery and start drafting national policies.

In terms of **timeliness**, the response faced an initial freeze and trust-building phase, and a second phase characterized by rapid programmatic scale-up. Immediately after the fall of the regime in December 2024, the programmatic response was stopped for approximately six months: this halt was primarily due to the mistrust of the new caretaker authorities toward the UN system, perceived to have been too closely aligned with the former regime. During this period, the caretaker authorities conducted a comprehensive "inventory" of UN operations and funding. At the same time, the country experienced a massive institutional vacuum, as many civil servants were dismissed or fled, leaving Ministries without technical capacity. In parallel from the UN side, concerns were raised regarding the extent of permissible engagement with the new authorities, directly targeted by international sanctions (concerns that were later resolved). UNDP utilized this period to build trust with the new authorities through in-country sustained effort, high-level missions from Regional Bureau and HQ, and practical support that slowly reset the relationship and positioned UNDP as a partner of choice during the transition.

The response entered its second phase in the summer of 2025, characterized by an intense scale-up in both delivery and resource mobilization as the situation normalized and authorizations were granted. The CO managed to jump from a delivery of approximately USD13.6M in mid-June to over USD 80M by the end of the year. Similarly, resource mobilization massively surged from the approximately USD 7M of the summer to about USD 150M within the same 6-month period, bringing Syria at the top of regional resource mobilization.

While the first six months period represents per se a delay, all key informants consulted coincide that it would have not been possible to reduce this timeframe, and that building the relationship with the new caretaker authorities was critical to the role UNDP has played since. Building trust in a post-conflict environment after 14 years of war "cannot be done overnight" and necessarily starts from cautious positions. In fact, internal reflections suggest that attempts to accelerate the process were often counterproductive.

This initial stall had however a benefit, as it gave the CO the necessary time to strategize, readjust, restructure, and bring in new capacities; once the Government was ready to engage in mid-2025, UNDP was prepared to execute a rapid programmatic scale-up, and was able to deliver the double of what it did in previous years.

SYRIA TECHNICAL ASSISTANCE FACILITY

The **Syria Technical Assistance Facility (STAF)** was established in 2025 as a rapid response to the immediate needs in the early days of the transition phase. Operating as an Engagement Facility under the Direct Implementation Modality (DIM), it functions as a platform to provide demand-driven technical expertise, policy guidance, and essential equipment to caretaker authorities and various Government Ministries. It has quickly become a flagship initiative providing critical upstream support for governance, policy development, and technical capacity building, and serves as an engagement platform with national authorities, enabling a close dialogue with them. The Facility is currently transitioning from its initial request-driven approach and design into a proactive, Government-owned "one-stop-shop": this evolution aims at combining all technical demands into a consolidated and coherent plan.

What Worked Well. STAF key results include “progress towards policy and strategy development goals, building local and regional master-planning capacities, undertaking national social protection and multi-dimensional poverty workshops, developing project proposals for donor consideration, generation of investor dialogues and establishing new partnerships with private sector and civil society.”[1] In addition to the policy and technical support, STAF also contributed to emergency responses, such as road clearance and early warning systems during the 2025 wildfires, and equipped Ministries with essential assets (laptops, printers, and furniture) and rehabilitation of their offices, which allowed them to resume basic service delivery.

The STAF successfully functioned as an "upstream" instrument that rapidly established UNDP as a partner of choice for the new caretaker authorities by responding directly to their technical and institutional needs. A core result of the STAF was the recruitment and embedding of 48 specialized Syrian diaspora and local experts across 6 Ministries/Government Institutions, a "reverse brain drain" approach that addressed acute capacity gaps in public institutions. Its institutional strengthening function worked: for example, the Planning and Statistical Commission, supported through STAF, was later tasked by the Presidential Office to lead the National Development Plan, for which it also requested UN’s support, engaging the organization in a major national and strategic initiative.

The use of Syrian nationals as advisors embedded in Ministries was a deliberate and appropriate choice. The Government was not yet comfortable with international experts in sensitive positions, and Syrian professionals, including those from diaspora, brought contextual knowledge and language fluency that internationals cannot easily provide. It was noted during consultations that one advisor initially funded by STAF by the end of the year had become Deputy Minister, having come off the UNDP payroll: this is a successful example of sustainable capacity transfer to which STAF has contributed.

What Did Not Work Well. Despite its successes, a persistent challenge is the facility's long-term financial sustainability. Initially funded with approximately USD 6.7M from internal TRAC2 and TRAC3 resources, it requires significant funding (currently estimated at approximately USD 20M) that external donors remain hesitant to provide for public sector capacity building, preferring ‘transactional’ funding approaches more directly linked to humanitarian outcomes, like refugee and IDP returns. The support provided to a selection of Ministries created some expectation management issues, as Government entities not yet supported express frustration that UNDP lacks the resources to provide them with similar assistance. The early implementation phase was request-driven and

[1] UNDP (2026), Syria Technical Assistance Facility. Technical Assistance on Demand

therefore reactive, a lesson that UNDP has learned and that is applying now in designing a more proactive and a consolidated technical assistance plan.

A disappointing evolution is that gender integration deteriorated across successive iteration of the conceptualization of STAF: in the original 2025 STAF design,[2] gender was a standalone output (Output 3) with a dedicated budget of nearly $760,000; by the February 2026 version,[3] gender had been relegated to a mainstreaming reference, with no standalone output, thus significantly weakening both the importance and weight assigned to it, and the practical and programmatic implications.

STABILIZATION PLUS

The UNDP programmatic offer was originally a scenario-based programmatic framework, which underwent significant refinement following the February 2025 multidisciplinary scoping mission, that brought together experts from the Regional Hub, HQ, and the CO to identify programmatic opportunities in key areas of UNDP expertise. By March 2025, it evolved into the 'Stabilization Plus' framework, which informed the creation of the Syria Technical Assistance Facility (STAF) for "upstream" policy support, in addition to stabilization activities. Currently (early 2026), the CO has designed a Syria Stabilization Facility (SSF) aimed at serving as the "downstream" operational arm of the framework. In line with UNDP's stabilization best practice and direct technical support and capacity building from the Crisis Bureau, the SSF is organized in three main pillars:

- Pillar 1. Security in Communities
- Pillar 2. Infrastructure and Service Delivery
- Pillar 3. Income Support

One of its key objectives is to facilitate the sustainable return of displaced populations by improving the physical and economic conditions in areas of high return or those experiencing localized unrest.

Across all versions, the Stabilization Plus framework organised UNDP's offer around governance and public sector reform, economic recovery and livelihoods, and energy and environment. These mapped broadly onto UNDP's corporate strategic plan objectives and also reflected what the new Syrian authorities consistently indicated as key priorities. Forced displacement solutions and gender equality appeared as cross-cutting themes, though as discussed below, the institutional weight given to gender shifted over time.

What worked well. The framework was built from the beginning to be flexible; this was a deliberate architectural choice that proved sound given the fluid dynamics in the country, which materialized in a mix of scenarios in different areas during the course of 2025. The design anchored the scale-up of interventions to recognition, engagement, and stability, thus avoiding being blocked by the unpredictability of the context, and focused in the early phases on 'less controversial' activities (like energy, for example).

In terms of positioning, it also worked: the Stabilization Plus framework gave the organization a substantive and coherent narrative to present to donors and Government counterparts during a period when very little was advancing programmatically. According to key informants, this is one of the reasons why UNDP was perceived as a key strategic development partner on the ground. One of the consequences was that the CO nearly doubled its programmatic delivery (from approximately USD 40M in prior years to USD 80M by the end of 2025) and mobilized almost USD 150M against the USD 39M of the previous year. While this growth is the reflection of many factors, the credibility established through the programmatic offer was essential to donor confidence.

The alignment between the Stabilization Plus framework and the STAF as its delivery vehicle was coherent. The STAF's demand-driven design operationalized exactly the flexibility that the

[2] UNDP (2024), TRAC 2 & 3 Country Allocation [Syria Country Office]
[3] UNDP (2026), Syria Technical Assistance Facility. Technical Assistance on Demand

Stabilization Plus framework required: it was impossible to pre-programme what Ministries would need because nobody knew what the new authorities would ask for (including, in the early stages, the authorities themselves). Having a facility that could respond to requests as they emerged was the right choice for the framework's contingent logic.

What did not work well. Effective stabilization in strategic, conflict-affected locations in Syria has been partially delayed by external factors beyond UNDP’s control. By mid-2025, UNDP was ready to launch stabilization interventions in Syria, with expressed interest from Germany as the main donor to the GFFO–UNDP Stabilization Response Mechanism and openness signaled by the Government. However, initial allocations under the SRM were prioritized for the Gaza response, and confirmation of targeted support to strategic locations in Syria, such as Sweida, only became available early 2026. By the time of the February 2026 CMST, SRM engagement had therefore not progressed beyond a USD 1.5 million seed commitment, primarily directed to Sweida Governorate. This initial allocation is expected to serve as catalytic funding for stabilization in targeted, strategic locations under SSF, with potential to mobilize additional donor contributions.

The impact of the Gaza ceasefire on the Syria SRM mission and subsequent launch of the programme warrants a reflection on the opportunity to approach stabilization from a regional perspective. Rather than treating Syria, Lebanon, and Gaza as separate issues addressed individually by COs, it would perhaps be beneficial to approach the stabilization challenge regionally, as these issues are expressions of interlinked regional dynamics. The three countries share borders and population movements, and some actors in the countries drive instability in neighbouring ones. Besides contextual differences, the stabilization challenge is similar: building legitimate state presence in territories formerly controlled by non-state armed groups, in societies deeply fragmented, and against a backdrop of weak or collapsed public institutions and acute economic distress. UNDP has experience on a regional stabilization approach: the Lake Chad Basin regional initiative, which worked precisely because it addressed cross-border dynamics through the shared architecture of the Lake Chad Basin Commission (LCBC) and a joint plan that provided strategic coherence to programmatic interventions in the four countries involved. UNDP could reflect on the opportunity of a regional framework with shared stabilization objectives and country-specific programming, anchored in a political compact led by a relevant regional body (in a way similar to the LCBC leadership). While the complexity of the region and its recent additional conflict dynamics, as well as the many advantages and risks of a regional approach go beyond the scope of the present AAR, it is worth for UNDP to explore this possibility.

GENDER EQUALITY

The **integration of gender equality** offers a mixed picture. The Socio-Economic Impact Assessment (SEIA), one of the analytical foundations for the crisis response, contained very limited sex-disaggregated data and minimal analysis of the differentiated impact of the conflict on women and men. The assessment methodology and data collection did not sufficiently take into account gender considerations, and according to key informants Syria's Central Bureau of Statistics does not routinely produce or share gender-disaggregated data, while data collectors are not trained to recognise and document differentiated needs and experiences. The presence of female enumerators, if not accompanied by a methodology that captures gender-differentiated vulnerabilities or impacts, is insufficient for a proper gender-responsive data collection, and consequently there cannot be a structured gender analysis with incomplete data.

Nevertheless, it should be noted that the CO Gender Team prior to December 2024 had conducted six gender analyses; following the political transition, new analyses were paused, due to security incidents across multiple governorates and large-scale population displacement, planned to restart in mid-2025. A first post-transition participatory gender analysis was being finalized at the time of the review.

The multidisciplinary scoping mission of February 2025 did include a brief analysis of how women were impacted by the conflict, and some gender-relevant recommendations, notably including gender equality as a principle of engagement for UNDP, proposing support to the national women's machinery, the Syrian Commission for Family Affairs and Population (SCFAP), the rehabilitation of Women's Safe Centers (WSC) and technical assistance and targeted capacity development to integrate gender equality in service delivery.

The STAF's treatment of gender evolved significantly across its different iterations: the earlier STAF design included a dedicated "Output 3: Advancing Gender Equality through targeted support for evidence-based programming". This was a substantive commitment, encompassing gender-sensitive data and national assessments, support to the Women, Peace and Security agenda, women's economic empowerment, women's leadership in governance, in the political transition and in peacebuilding, and expansion of the Fadfada digital MHPSS platform, including for women and youth. The allocated budget for gender activities was approximately USD 760,000, around 19% of the programme total of USD 4M, comfortably above the corporate threshold of 15% funding allocation to GEN3 activities.

In the newer project document (February 2026), however, this architecture changed substantially: gender shifted from a standalone output to a cross-cutting principle, with a brief reference to "Inclusive and Gender-Responsive Development" as one of several added values of UNDP and a statement that "gender equality will be systematically mainstreamed across all training and capacity-building efforts." This formulation constitutes a much weaker integration than the dedicated output that preceded it.

The STAF deployed numerous technical experts to Government Ministries; it was noted that the terms of reference (ToRs) for these UNV positions did not systematically include a gender component, and that gender mainstreaming in practice depended on the CO Gender Team direct engagement with individual experts, rather than on a systematic and structural approach at the origin.

The SSF concept note contains very limited references to gender equality, and only mentions gender-specific cash-for-work initiatives under the Pillar dedicated to immediate stabilization income support. This reflects an emerging pattern of gender being noted in passing rather than designed in programmatic interventions from the outset (as it was initially done).

It was also noted that programmatic revisions of documents repeatedly led to text on gender equality being removed (apparently, on account of wording limits), particularly during regional-level revisions; this is not consistent with UNDP's corporate commitment to gender equality, which is not an optional addendum.

Despite these setbacks, the picture of the integration of gender equality in the CO is more positive: there is an extensive network of gender champions, including senior management; gender equality has been internally designated as a top priority, and it is included as the fourth pillar of the Country Programme Document under development. The existing programme portfolio covers multiple interventions including Women's Safe Centres, women's networks, WPS programming, and engagement of men and boys. It is noted that the current team's capacity (one specialist and one programme assistant) is insufficient for the extent of its coordination and implementation responsibilities; also, during a recent realignment process, it was reported that the sole programme lead position not upgraded was the gender one, resulting in reduced formal authority and symbolic devaluation of the gender programme compared to other programmatic pillars. Since the new CPD includes gender as a 4th pillar, this situation should be rapidly corrected.

ADDITIONAL OBSERVATIONS

Multiple AARs have highlighted the catalytic and strategic value of TRAC3 resources. However, these resources are limited and usually allocated to a maximum of USD 1 – 1.5M per country or crisis. Moreover, the global funding crisis affecting humanitarian action and development is likely to further reduce these resources, if that has not already happened.

A suggestion was advanced during consultations to consider the possibility to provide a loan to COs, so that the demonstrated strategic and catalytic value of TRAC3 funds can be expanded and built upon. Other UN agencies are successfully using this approach, for example UNICEF has the Emergency Programme Fund (EPF), through which immediate resources can be deployed to a CO on a reimbursement basis. It is recommended that UNDP explore a similar arrangement.

OPERATIONAL ASPECTS OF THE RESPONSE

SPECIAL MEASURES

Following Syria's L3 designation, the CO could access two categories of Special Measures (SM): the pre-approved ones, available to all L3 country offices without further action, and exceptional special measures: country-specific flexibilities beyond the pre-approved menu, that were customized to the Syria context and specifically approved by BMS. All SM were formally activated in January 2025, and as of the last CSMT in February 2026 they have been extended for an additional year.

The CO used 86 cases of **pre-approved measures** with a combined delivery value of approximately USD 8.1M, representing roughly 8% of the total impact of special measures across the 12 countries that activated them in 2025, broadly in line with the average per-country use. A table with details of the special measures utilized is included in Annex 04.

The HR measures were among the most extensively used: they were applied in at least 51 cases across the review period, covering direct hiring, job classification, and devolution of national staff recruitments. This last aspect was described as particularly important to ensure speed of recruitment as the office scaled up rapidly its programmatic implementation. Procurement measures and particularly the increase of the Request for Quotation (RFQ) threshold from USD 200,000 to USD 300,000 was used eight times for a combined value of over USD 2M, including for rehabilitation work, renewable energy and solid waste removal. Financial measures relative to petty cash and project cash advance were used 19 times, for a total value of approximately USD 135,000.

Programmatic special measures were used instead less frequently, for a total of 13 times, although their total estimated value ascends at USD 3.8M, slightly less than half the total. The low-value grant measure was a particularly significant tool: under normal UNDP policy, any single NGO or implementing partner is capped at USD 300,000 in total low-value grants within a programming cycle. The special measure removed this cap, allowing UNDP to continue working with the same partner with a per-grant ceiling of USD 150,000 but no cumulative cap. This was operationally important in a context where new partnerships are risky, and where partners with existing UNDP familiarity and clearances are scarce. This measure accounted for approximately USD 1.4M, the second largest after the waiver of micro-assessments (which accounted for USD 1.7M).

Syria CO was also granted 8 **exceptional measures** on HR, procurement and finance. The most distinctive one was an increased delegation of procurement authority of USD 500,000, specifically negotiated with RBAS support, relevant for large civil works and infrastructure contracts, including a USD 2.2M wastewater treatment plant and a USD 2.1M civil works contract. Additionally, the CO benefited from a waiver allowing payment of local vendors in USD, when hyperinflation, a liquidity crisis and the collapse of the banking system would have otherwise blocked UNDP from being able to engage with local suppliers. UNDP was forced to route payments through vendors with prior UNDP contracts, like LTAs outside Syria, and third-party companies based in Iraq and capable of providing USD inside Syria; both the UNDP Treasury and the UN Treasury were instrumental in facilitating a solution to the CO and provided support throughout the crisis.

The CO has consistently expressed appreciation for the usefulness of Special Measures; the combined effect of pre-approved and exceptional measures, together with the deployment of four Crisis Bureau-funded UNVs (initially dedicated to procurement, then to a technical evaluation cell), created an enabling environment for the rapid scale-up that was reflected in the total USD 80M programmatic delivery of 2025.

The most significant operational constraint that the CO faced was cash management. The pre-approved and exceptional measures included petty cash and project cash advance provisions, but these are structured for 'normal' crisis conditions. Syria's banking system collapsed in the transition period, liquidity vanished, and formal financial transfers became nearly impossible; the CO reported having USD in its bank accounts but being unable to distribute it. Special measures as currently designed were insufficient for this reality, and a suggestion has been advanced to develop further measures for cash management in specific exceptional circumstances, including the ability to hold and distribute larger volumes of cash, and to use alternative distribution channels, with appropriate the safeguards and SOPs to manage the increased risks. UNDP Treasury, through the UN, facilitated cash import as an extraordinary measure given the specific situation of Syria.

In addition to the financial value of the SM cases, it could be interesting for the organization to calculate the savings in time that these measures allow in each response: for example an estimation of the average time required for a GCCS recruitment, versus a recruitment conducted at country level; or of the time required for a micro-assessment, versus the waiving of the same requirement. These can provide an estimation of the time savings in a crisis, which in turn could be used as a proxy indicator of efficiency and of the timeliness of the response, and encourage the expansion of some special measures to non-crisis contexts, thus contributing to a simplification of processes and an increase in efficiency at large.

SURGE

There was only one SURGE deployment in the traditional sense, as the CO from the beginning preferred funding rather than deployed personnel, due to uncertainty and evolving Government demands; besides that single international deployment, some technical advisory missions like the mine action ones were funded through SURGE, as were some UNV deployments to the CO.

Another support provided by the Crisis Bureau and partially funded through SURGE was the deployment of the Mine Action Specialist in two missions in June and September 2025. The immediate programmatic trigger was Project Revive, a Korean-funded initiative of approximately USD 10M, of which around USD 500,000 were earmarked for mine action and debris management. Engagement with the National Mine Action Centre (NMAC) was also a key goal, to strengthen UNDP's position on capacity building of the national mine action authority, which falls under UNDP's mandate according to the UN mine action policy framework. After the 1st mission, it was recommended to hire a dedicated mine action technical advisor and SURGE funds were approved for a six-months timeframe; however, the position was not hired at the time. The CO is currently exploring the possibility of a shared mine action advisor with another CO. The mine action missions were in themselves successful as they were strategically sound and generated concrete recommendations, however the critical follow-through action of hiring a technical advisor was not taken, potentially leading to a missed opportunity in positioning UNDP solidly in this area. Nevertheless, another opportunity is arising as in early 2026 Syria was under consideration as a pilot for a joint UN mine action roadmap, and a joint UNDP–UNMAS assessment mission planned for March to develop a comprehensive and holistic mine action strategy for the country.

CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

CONCLUSIONS

Syria's 2024 political transition presented UNDP with an exceptionally complex operating environment: a country emerging from 14 years of conflict, with collapsed institutions, a devastated economy, and new authorities that were initially very distrustful of the UN system. Against this backdrop, the CO ability to pivot from a restricted humanitarian operating mode to a broader stabilization and development response, deliver over USD 80M, and mobilize approximately USD 150M, represents a significant result. Besides the external circumstances that have contributed (like donor interest and support), it is clear that such a feat could not have been achieved without the committed and extensive engagement of the organization at all levels, primarily from the CO but also from RBAS and HQ Bureaus at managerial and technical levels alike.

The six-month trust-building period, although it stalled programmatic activities, had the positive effect of allowing the CO time to get truly ready for when the authorities would consent to programmatic activities; this was an unusual gift of time, especially considering the frequently hectic pace at which these kinds of transitions usually take place. Moreover, while under the previous regime only humanitarian activities were allowed and therefore UNDP's role was limited, the new regime was interested in development and therefore the organization had the space and opportunity to shine in what is its core mandate and where it has the strongest expertise and unrivalled capacity.

At headquarters level, the corporate response was swift and strategic. The L3 declaration was timely, the Crisis Board mobilised rapidly, and the decision to extend the L3 designation throughout 2025 and into 2026 was sound given the context. The deployment of senior leadership in support to the CO was the right call, and the Administrator's participation at the Brussels Conference elevated development issues in a forum that would otherwise have been dominated by humanitarian concerns. Support from HQ Bureaus created the enabling conditions for a rapidly scaling response once the conditions on the ground materialized.

AARs consistently demonstrate the catalytic value of TRAC funding, which serves as the seed source to kickstart initiatives that position UNDP well in the eyes of authorities, donors and partners, and contribute to develop or strengthen the organizations' credibility and consequently the trust other key actors have in it. In light of this, but mindful of the constrained financial landscape all UN agencies face since 2025, it can be concluded that TRAC resources must be protected from potential reductions, because of their essential and catalytic value in emergencies.

Structural challenges remain on some aspects of gender equality integration, and on the effectiveness of surge deployments and follow-up. Despite having the institutional architecture and the policies to ensure full integration of gender equality, this was progressively downgraded across successive iterations of some strategic or programmatic documents, which required constant vigilance and interventions from the Gender Team in country; this is a structural weakness that needs to be corrected, as gender equality is a corporate mandate and therefore a responsibility of all officers in the organization, not of a team or an individual, and not even of a CO.

With regards to SURGE deployments, only very limited sources were available but anecdotical information points to the risk of ineffectiveness if SURGE deployments are externally driven rather than requested by the CO, as it was the case for the only SURGE deployment in Syria. It is recommended that this aspect is further explored in successive AARs.

At regional level, the performance was strong on programming support and uneven on gender. RBAS and the Regional Hub provided strong value through the multidisciplinary scoping mission of February 2025 and multiple follow-on technical missions, which contributed substantially to the development of a CO coherent programmatic offer. The Regional Director's personal engagement was a double-edged asset — opening doors to the new authorities while also carrying relational risks — but on balance, key informants considered it beneficial. The repeated removal of gender content from key documents, treating it as "extra wording," is inconsistent with UNDP's corporate commitments to gender equality and one that needs to be addressed.

Continuity and in-depth knowledge of the context are an important enabling factor for a successful strategic and programmatic positioning. The case of Syria offers several examples of this: the implication of the RD who is a Syrian national with profound knowledge of the context and strong ties in country; the continuity of at least part of CO senior management to accompany the transition, in a critical moment in which bringing in a newcomer would have likely been counterproductive; the appointment in a senior management position of a regional specialist with extensive knowledge of the Syrian context, are all examples of the perhaps obvious observation that context knowledge and understanding are powerful ingredients for a successful response. This fact is worth reminding given the inherent nature of UN appointments which are subject to turnover. Other AARs (for example the recent Lebanon one) have similarly highlighted that previous substantive engagement with the CO and the country contribute positively to the overall effectiveness and timeliness of the response.

At country office level, the response was very strong in its strategic design and execution. The CO demonstrated considerable resilience and adaptability: it built trust with a Government that was initially very cautious with the UN, developed a credible programmatic offer under conditions of high uncertainty, launched the STAF as a functioning platform which in time embedded over 48 advisors across 6 Ministries/Government entities, and ramped up delivery sharply in the second half of 2025. The demand-driven, Government-owned approach to technical assistance was the right strategic choice for the context, and has also coherently evolved towards a more planned and less reactive assistance with time. The CO's preference for funding over deployed personnel was a legitimate and sound operating philosophy, also consistent with capacity strengthening and sustainability considerations. Some opportunities were missed with regards to SURGE support and deployments, which are in part being corrected right now.

One structural finding cuts across all levels: gender equality is sometimes still treated as an add-on rather than an integrated responsibility of all staff. Despite very positive individual or team performances (for example, the CO overall, the commitment of the Gender Team, and the commitment of the CO senior management to gender), corporate performance as a whole is not fully satisfactory: gender equality was mostly absent from the SEIA, progressively weakened in programmatic documents, functionally absent in UNV ToRs, and highly dependent on the advocacy of a single CO unit, under-resourced for the extent of its mainstreaming, coordination and programmatic responsibility. This is not a CO issue: it rather reflects a systemic deficit in corporate culture that should be addressed through clearer accountability measures.

RECOMMENDATIONS

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR SYRIA COUNTRY OFFICE

Recommendation 1: Strengthen gender equality as a programmatic pillar

Reinstate gender equality as a dedicated programmatic output in the current STAF iteration, and in other programme initiatives as relevant, including the SSF, with a minimum 15% GEN3 budget allocation, gender-specific outputs and indicators as needed. Upgrade the gender Programme Lead position to the same level as the other pillars/Programme Leads of the new CPD to provide adequate capacity and weight to all programmatic pillars; expand the Gender Team with an additional programme office at NOB level. Report progress at future Crisis Board or CMST meetings.

Recommendation 2: Embed gender equality requirements systematically in all ToRs, programmatic and monitoring documents

Introduce a CO directive for a mandatory gender review on all ToRs (to be conducted by the Head of Section), on all project design documents (to be conducted by the Gender Team), and on all monitoring frameworks (to be conducted by the M&E Specialist). Integrate gender performance into annual staff performance objectives across all teams.

Track progress quarterly in CO management meetings, with a target of 100% new ToRs, programme document and monitoring frameworks containing a meaningful gender component by end of 2026. Track staff performance progress annually.

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR RBAS

Recommendation 1: Establish a mandatory gender equality review for all regional products

Introduce a regional directive for a mandatory gender review on all products developed, supported or cleared by RBAS, including ToRs (to be conducted by the Head of Section), programmatic documents (to be conducted by the Gender Specialist), and monitoring frameworks (to be conducted by the M&E Specialist); ensure including a minimum budget allocations of 15% to GEN3 activities and measurable gender equality indicators. Embed gender objective in the substance of governance, recovery, and other programmes and use specific inputs relevant to the sector and measurable rather than generic formulations likely to elicit resistance (for example: 'support a minimum participation of 30% of women in local dispute resolution committees', or 'provide financial incentives for women-owned SMEs', instead of 'ensuring gender-responsiveness of programmatic activities'). Track progress in RB management meetings, with a target of 100% new ToRs, programme document and monitoring frameworks containing a meaningful gender component by end of 2026. Produce a short annual report on gender equality integration in regional programmes.

Recommendation 2: Explore the feasibility of a regional stabilization facility

Explore the feasibility of establishing a regional stabilization facility with country windows covering Syria, Gaza, and Lebanon, to ensure a more coherent and balanced allocation of support across interlinked crises. Given the cross-border nature of conflict dynamics, population movements, and shared stabilization challenges, a regional framework with common objectives and country-specific programming could help mitigate the risk of individual contexts being deprioritized due to shifting operational or funding priorities. Lessons from UNDP's regional stabilization experience, including in the Lake Chad Basin, could inform the design of such an approach.

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR THE CRISIS BUREAU

Recommendation 1: Address gender equality as a corporate culture issue in crisis response

Commission a gender review of all UNDP L3 crisis response in the last 1-2 years; develop with BPPS a mandatory gender integration requirement in all crisis response frameworks, including a gender equality checklist for all crisis planning and programmatic documents, and add a standing gender equality agenda item to every Crisis Board and CMST meeting. Conduct a mandatory training on gender in emergencies for Crisis Bureau, BERA, BMS and Regional Bureaus; include gender equality mainstreaming as performance evaluation item for all Crisis Bureau and Regional Bureaus staff.

Recommendation 2: Assess eligibility and implications of high-impact Special Measures for extension to non-crisis contexts

In collaboration with BMS, quantify time savings brought by SM in 2025 on average per measure and per country. Assess financial value and other relevant metrics, to consider the opportunity for expansion of the most relevant SM to non-crisis contexts for increased efficiency and simplified administrative burden, with the opportune mitigation and safeguarding procedures.

Recommendation 3: Evaluate the implications and practical aspects of providing TRAC3 "loans" to COs beyond the existing SOP standards.

Given the documented catalytic value of TRAC3 resources, assess the possibility, implications and practical aspects of offering TRAC3 'loans' of up to USD 5M to COs, in addition to the TRAC3 grants already provided under the Crisis SOPs.

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR BMS

Recommendation 1: Promote efficiency through the expansion of high-impact Special Measures to non-crisis contexts

In collaboration with the Crisis Bureau, quantify time savings brought by SM in 2025 on average per measure and per country. Assess financial value and other relevant metrics, to consider the opportunity for expansion of the most relevant SM to non-crisis contexts for increased efficiency and simplified administrative burden, with the opportune mitigation and safeguarding procedures.

ANNEXES

ANNEX 1 - TORS OF THE CONSULTANCY

TERM OF REFERENCE

After Action Review for UNDP's Response to Crises in Lebanon, Sudan and Syria

GENERAL INFORMATION

Services/Work Description: Individual Consultancy

Project/Program Title: UNDP's Crisis Bureau

Post Title: After Action Review for UNDP's Response to Lebanon, Syria and Sudan Crises

Duty Station: home based **Duration:** 30 days (10 consultancy days per country: Lebanon, Syria, and Sudan)

Expected Start Date: 12th November 2025

Expected End Date: 30th May 2026

I. BACKGROUND / PROJECT DESCRIPTION

Crisis Bureau After Action Reviews (AARs):

UNDP carries out After Action Reviews as structured reflections after a crisis to help the organization identify strengths and weaknesses, positive and negative lessons learned, how to sustain what was done well and identify areas for improvement with a particular focus on the Crisis Bureau response. The AAR formulates actionable recommendations for improving UNDP crisis response policy and practice. As per the corporate accountability framework for crisis response, the UNDP Crisis Bureau leads the planning, coordination, roll out and dissemination of corporate AARs.

Crisis Background

Lebanon Crisis: In October 2023, hostilities between Hezbollah and Israel erupted, triggered by the Gaza war. Fighting escalated sharply in September 2024, when Israel killed Hezbollah's leader Hassan Nasrallah and intensified airstrikes across southern Lebanon, Beirut's southern suburbs, and the Bekaa. A ceasefire was brokered in November 2024. The conflict caused extensive destruction, particularly in the South of Lebanon: over 64,000

ANNEX 2 - METHODOLOGY

UNDP's response to the crisis was examined reflecting on the following key questions and sub-questions:

Questions	Sub-questions
Overall Clarity and Timeliness of **Decision Making** for the Response	Examine the **timeliness and effectiveness of strategic decisions and actions** taken by HQ, RBAS/Regional Hub and the CO
	Examine UNDP's ability to take on a **"whole of UNDP"** approach to the response efforts
	Assess the compliance with UNDP's **Crisis Response and Recovery SOPs and Supplementary Protocols** in decision-making processes and in the response as a whole
	Assess how UNDP corporate technical and programmatic expertise was **leveraged to support the CO's crisis response**
	Assess how UNDP corporate technical and programmatic expertise was **leveraged to support the CO's programmatic positioning**
Timeliness and Effectiveness of **Programmatic Response** and the **use of Corporate Funds**	Review the **pertinence** and **timeliness** of UNDP's **programmatic response** and use of **corporate funds** (TRAC3 and Funding Windows), especially focusing on how the CB support was used catalytic for the expansion and sustainability of crisis response and recovery
	Assess the extent to which the (corporate funded) crisis programmes were **gender responsive**.
	Examine how **adjustments** were made to the ongoing projects in response to the crisis (including the identification of new programmes).
	Examine the timeliness and usefulness of **key assessments/analysis** conducted (including if applicable RAPIDA, housing and building damage assessments (HBDA), socio-economic impact analysis (SEIA), the PDNA/RDNA, etc.)
Timeliness and effectiveness of the **Operational Response**	Review the **timeliness** and **effectiveness** of the overall **operational response**
	Review the **effectiveness** and **cost-efficiency** of **SURGE deployments** (including gender balance, any surge deployment on gender equality and women's empowerment, management of SURGE advisors in the country, collaboration between SURGE advisors and the country office team)

The light AAR will be articulated in four phases: inception, data collection, analysis and reporting.

1. INCEPTION

The **inception phase** includes a brief desk review of key documents provided by the Crisis Bureau, as well as initial discussions with selected key informants to determine the key priorities for the AAR and focus aspects to be analyzed, to center subsequent data collection. The inception phase ends with the present Inception Report (IR).

2. DATA COLLECTION

The **data collection phase** will comprise a more in-depth desk review including further documentation provided by the CO, Crisis Bureau, RBAS and others and identification of key stakeholders for remote Key Informant Interviews (KII).

Desk review – Documents collected during the initial desk review are included in Annex II – Bibliography. Additional documents will be identified and reviewed during the data collection phase.

Key informants will be interviewed online using a simple guideline aimed at prompting reflection and discussion on the key aspects of UNDP crisis response. The table in Annex III indicates a list of informants interviewed. Key informants will be consulted according to the main areas of inquiry and/or the specific areas of focus and their role in each aspect of the response. The AAR will ensure to the extent possible a gender-balanced approach to key informant interviews. Additional interviews may be organized during the data collection phase if further information or clarifications are needed.

Limitations: The timeframe allocated to the AAR requires strict prioritization in the selection of key informants. Consequently, it is not possible to extend data collection to additional stakeholders whose perspectives could provide valuable insights. This constitutes a methodological limitation resulting from the parameters established for the exercise, rather than from the review approach itself. In particular, given that the AAR is framed as an internal exercise focused on corporate support to the CO, it does not include consultations with external actors (for example, donors and IRG) whose views would nonetheless enrich the analysis. It is strongly recommended for future AARs that the time and resources allocated are expanded to allow for a broader data collection and analysis.

3. ANALYSIS

After the data collection, in the **analysis phase** all information captured through the desk review, interviews, group discussion will be triangulated and analyzed according to the three main subjects of the AAR. The analysis of the crisis response will be conducted against criteria of pertinence, timeliness, efficiency, and effectiveness, to understand what worked well and what could have been done better or differently, according to the AAR methodology. As the AAR is not an evaluation there will not be an assessment of the impact of UNDP's interventions.

A focus **on gender equality** will be maintained throughout the AAR, answering a specific sub-question that looks at assessing the extent to which the (corporate funded) crisis programmes were gender responsive, and assessing the inclusion of gender-responsive aspects in SURGE deployments.

Lessons learned and good practices will be identified as they emerge, and will be included in the analysis and AAR report.

4. REPORTING

A **draft report** will be produced and shared with key UNDP stakeholders for comments and observations, as well as validation of findings and recommendations. After review from UNDP a **final AAR report** will be elaborated together with an Executive Summary and a slide deck for presentation to key stakeholders.

ANNEX 3 - LISTS OF KEY INFORMANTS

The staff consulted for the AAR includes:

Name	Function	M/F
Syria CO		
Mohammed Mudawi	Resident Representative a.i.	M
Sudipto Mukerjee	Former Resident Representative	M
Rawhi Afaghani	Deputy Resident Representative	M
Yasser Drei Kamakshi Yakthumba	Operations Manager Operations Specialist	M F
Leena Taha	Gender Specialist	F
Regional and HQ Bureaux		

Devanand Ramiah	C3RT Team Leader	M
Hiroshi Kuwata Roxanne Lette	Team Leader – Arab States (C3RT) Crisis Response Analyst (C3RT)	M F
Glaucia Boyer	Global Advisor – Stabilization and Reintegration	F
Seán Moorhouse	CB Mine Action Advisor	F
Nesreen Al-Hebshi	BMS	F
Kiye Mwakawago Navindra Persaud	Project Manager, Crisis Bureau Programme Specialist, Crisis Bureau	M M
Ahmad Alhammal	Regional Advisor, RBAS	M

ANNEX 4 - SPECIAL MEASURES

The table below shows the special measures approved for Syria and their use.

Region: RBAS
Expiration Date: 31.12.2025

Measure #	Measure Details	Type of Request / Measure	Policy Group	Category	# Cases	Value $	Outcome (Narrative on usefulness or limitations)		
1	Access a sub-set of JDs and ToRs suited for crisis response and recovery (already pre-classify via GSSC).	Pre-Approved			10		We used around 10 pre-classified TORs; however, even when using generic (pre-classified) TORs, we are still required to prepare a Note to the File and submit the TORs to the Classification Team for their review and clearance, which usually takes around 3 to 5 working days.	Was any of the 28 Recruitment done using the Pre-Classified TOR?	Done
2	Devolution of national recruitment cases (FTAs + PSA) (inclusive of requests from Inter-Agencies-PPSA) to the local HR team at the COs. International recruitments to be performed by GSSC unless CO demonstrates capacity	Pre-Approved	Operations	Human Resources	0	-			
3	Direct recruitment of 30 project staff on regular IPSA / NPSA contracts for up to 2 years per CO to be delegated to the Resident Representative. Approval to skip the mandatory written questions in the desk review for TA and PSA contracts.	Pre-Approved			28	$ 981.684,00	This allowed our CO to respond to field needs and avoid the 90-day period required to complete the recruitment process. The 28 positions covered a mix of roles required to ensure continuity of operations and rapid delivery in the field. They mainly fall under the following functional areas: * Programme / Area Coordination & Management * Technical Project Implementation: * Economics & Advisory Support:	Can you add some more info on the roles of these 28 and how many projects? Can you also share how many female candidates were selected?	Done

5	Delegation of authority to the Resident Representative for direct recruitments, without Regional Bureau oversight, for up to 20 TAs positions per CO (up to P5)	Pre-Approved		5	$ 1.210.800,00	* Operations & Support Functions 25 NPSA 3 IPSA 12 Females The direct hire using the TA modality enabled our CO to address field needs and avoid the 90-day calendar requirement to finalize the recruitment process. These 5 TA roles covered key areas as follows: * Partnerships & Resource Mobilization: Partnership Advisor * Community Security / Access to Justice: Community Security and Access to Justice Specialist * Operations & Business Support: Operations Specialist * Programme Delivery & Coordination: Head of Project Management Unit * Conflict Prevention & Peacebuilding: Conflict Prevention and Peacebuilding Specialist	Can you add some more info on the roles of these 5TAs	Done
7	Increase RFQ limit to US$ 300,000. **Alternatively Utilize the Simplified RFQ Template (Link) for cases up to US$ 200,000.**	Pre-Approved	Procurement	8	2.018.679,00	During 2025, eight RFQ cases were executed under this measure, with individual case values ranging between USD 200K and USD 300K. The combined value of these eight cases totaled USD 2,018,679.	Can you elaborate a bit further to tell us about the scope of these 8 RFQs	The scope of theses cases are: - 4 cases for rehabilitation works: the two cases for schools, the third for bakeries, and the fourth for children & Maternity Hospital. - 2 cases for renuwable energy: the first for solar street lighting, and the second for Solar energy solution for drinking wells. - 2 cases for Solid waste removal: one for supply garbage bins & containers; and the

12	Increase Petty Cash (PCF) to US$ 10,000 and allow US$ 1,000 per transaction limit. OFM Annex 5 is mandatory.	Pre-Approved		Finance	12	80.169,76	PCF for Damascus office+ PPCF for Aleppo office (in SYP), in addition to that we used additional 20,000USD as PCF for Mahroukat and fuel	Is it only twice that the 10K float was replensihed? We are looking for the number of times it was and the total of those replenishment	second for Debris Collection and Removal. The PCF for Damascus office was replenished seven times, totaling $45,706.76. The PCF for Mahroukat and fuel was replenished five times, with a total of $34,463. This measure was not utilized for PPCF Aleppo office.
13	To increase Project Cash Advance (PCA) level to US$ 50,000 - with 60 days reporting period (liquidation). While allowing NPSA/IPSA holders as custodian up to US$ 25,000. OFM Annex 5 is mandatory	Pre-Approved			7	55.554,00	7 cases Project Cash Advance under GL account 16108		
14	The mandatory requirement for the micro-assessment for the NGO/CSO to be waived.	Pre-Approved	Programmatic	NGO Engagement	3	1.690.786,00	3 RPAs under implementation, could not be engaged without this special measure. Convening a Micro Assessment is a lengthy process . One of the agreements is with a very specialized NGO with Mine actions, and it is time sensitive as it takes place on parallel of Rubble removal in affected governorates via cash for work initiatives, which required clearance from mine and UXOs.		
15	Ability to engage with an entity if they were previously contracted by a sister agency within the past 24-36 months in the country. PCAT to be used along with UNCT clearance for case of registration challenge.	Pre-Approved	Programmatic		1	100.000,00	1 LVGs with an NGO licensed by the NE authorities, vetted by the steering committee of the WHPF, headed by the RC. One local NGO had previous agreement with the UNFPA, and the second was granted by UNWomen, The NGO was operating in the north east under Kurdish license (Syrian Women Charity) the scope of work is supporting women empowerment and integration into recovery in the north east of syria.	Any further info on their scope of work	Done

16	There will be no threshold for LVG grants for a programme cycle. The limit of US$ 150,000 per grant will remain, however, it is possible to issue multiple grants of US$ 150,000 pre grantee	Pre-Approved	Programmatic		6	1.353.000,00	6 partners with dual LVGs , noting that the second agreement took place after completion of the previous one, and based on good performance rating. 1- Two LVGs signed with Al Mabarrah the first one was to support livelihoods of females heading their households in " Sbeineh " via Vocational training and supporting starting their micro businesses, while the second was for light rehabilitation of most vunlerable families identified in the first LVG which increased positive impact on the targeted families in Sbeineh. 2- Two LVGs granted to Bahar (NNGO): the first was to rehabilitate Lattakia based Women safe Center, upon successful completion a second grant was provided to cover the soft components of operating the center that was supposed to be handed to be operated by the Ministry of social affairs, but the ministry had no resources to do so, thus the LVG secured operating the center and supporting women and girls protection and participation. 3- Two LVGs granted to RDC (Relief Development Center) : both were for providing prosthetics support to PWDs, the demand on the center was high in the first stage (as circa 28% of syrians are PWDs due to war and conflict) , the second grant was to cover the high demand on the center's support. given the very limited number of services providers of prosthetics support in Syria.	Any further info on their scope of work	Done

						4- Two grants for Sanad (Youth supporting NGO) ; the first was to Empowering young men and young women and PWDs through inclusive Digital Freelancing. and the second was a " The Innovation and Startup Ecosystem in Syria: Strategic Framework" the first was at the services level while the second was to support the MOSAL ministry's strategic framework. 5- Two grants for the Medical Doctors Syndicate to operate and manage Fadfada For Remote MHPSS Services, the syndicate is specialized and mandated in the subject matter of the project. 6- Ayadina Association which is a local NGO in Lattakia ; was granted for a Cash for Work Project related to wild fire fighting during the coastal area wild fire, as well as a grant funded by the WPHF for institutional capacity development.		
17	The approval authority of ad-hoc award of LVG shall be granted to RR in CO (or the designated head of the Business Unit) without any further conditions/procedures (e.g., the pro doc or the project board / steering committee)	Pre-Approved	Programmatic	0	-			
18	The approval authority shall be granted to RR in CO (or the designated head of Business Unit) on the selection decision of the NGO/CSO for Performance-Based Payments (PBP) agreement through collaborative advantage without a competitive process	Pre-Approved	Programmatic	3	300.000,00	3 PBP were approved with micro fianance entities / closer to social enterprises from Banks, to subsidize loans for MSMEs in 9 governorates. Access to finance proved to be one of the major obsticles to startups and MSMEs in Syria. That the interest on loans for startups and businesses is very high in Syria (25%) which limits access to finance, UNDP Syria subsidises 22% of the interest rate with	Can you elaborate on the mechanism for Micro finance and the MSMEs are engaged	Done

							remaining 3% to be covered by the borrower, which relaxes burden on startups and MSMEs. The 3 micro finance institutions provide the same services but each is covering specific governorates at the MFB reach.		
19	The threshold amount for an independent assessor will be increased to "over $1million".	Pre-Approved	Programmatic		0	-			
20	Waving the requirement for the agreement by the project board meeting / steering committee on the LVG modalities/arrangements. Grant the authority of approving the LVG modalities/arrangements to RR in CO (or the designated head of the BU).	Pre-Approved	Programmatic		0	-			
21	CO (Programme Manager) confirms programmatic results, RR approves the payment	Pre-Approved	Programmatic		0	-			
22	Delegate the decision to engage Private Sector from Crisis Board / Regional Director to Resident Representatives, up to US$ 1million	Pre-Approved	Programmatic	Private Sector	3	316.100,00	3 perfromance based agrreemetn sign with the private sector, particulary with 3 micro-finance banks to perform subsidized loans to MSMEs 109,700 99,200 107,200	Selection of the engaged private sector (micro-finance banks) was direct as only 4 micro-finance banks are exist in the country with limited geograghical coverage to each - 3 micro-finance banks already engaged with teh plan to engage with the forth. Acoordingly, the contracting was direct as sole providers in the market for the MSMEs	Done

								micor-fiance lending
23	Basic" pathways should be applied for Non-financial agreement and financial agreement ≤$150,000	Pre-Approved	Programmatic		0	-	potetnial for next year	
24	All quality assurance measures, including Social and Environmental Screening (SES) Procedures, shall be exempted for 12 months.	Pre-Approved	Programmatic		0	-		
25	The agreement of the government is recommended but shall not be mandatory as long as the PIP is implemented under DIM modality.	Pre-Approved	Programmatic	Prog/Project Initiation	0	-		
26	There will be no threshold for LVG grants for a programme cycle. The limit of $ 150,000 per grant will remain, however, it is possible to issue multiple grants of $ 150,000 pre grantee.	Pre-Approved	Programmatic		0	-		
					86	8.106.772,76		